ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Nefesh and Neshamah: What Makes Us Human?

Derech Hashem 3:1:1-3

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 1, paragraphs 1-3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 18 October 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Halfway through the book

After the break for the festivals the series resumed with Part 3. The Rabbi reintroduced the book, begun a year earlier. Derech Hashem was written by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto in the first part of the eighteenth century. Born in Italy, he later lived in Amsterdam and went to the Land of Israel, where he died young, at 38, in Akko. He wrote dozens of books, poetic and artistic in style, some as dialogues, for example between the intellect and the soul. His most famous is Mesillat Yesharim, but Derech Hashem is the basic book of Jewish thought, and it is extremely methodical, so it must be followed step by step.

There are four parts, and we are exactly halfway. Part 1 was about Hashem: what He is, the purpose of creation, humanity, and how a person's actions affect the universe. Part 2 was about hashgahah: why bad things happen to good people and good things to bad people, reward and punishment, gilgulim, the difference between Jews and non-Jews, the heavenly courtroom, and, just before Rosh Hashanah, astrology. The Rabbi asked the group to recall the Ramhal's conclusion on astrology: the concept is true, but it applies only to someone not directly under Hashem's hashgahah. "If you live your life with HaKadosh Barukh Hu, you don't need to worry for mazalot, don't need to be worried for ein hara." For the Rambam it is all nonsense.

Part 3: the soul, ruah hakodesh and prophecy

The title of Part 3 is "the soul of man, ruah hakodesh (Divine inspiration, or better, intuition), prophecy, and actions in the world that are not natural," including magic. It has only five chapters: the soul and its parts, ruah hakodesh, prophecy, and why Moshe is the most unique of all prophets.

It corresponds to the Rambam's sixth and seventh principles of faith: that prophecy is true, and that Moshe is the greatest prophet. Why must we believe in communication between the Divine and the human? Because otherwise we would have a Creator who made the world and left it to run on its own. To believe that Hashem created the world, we must also believe that He revealed to the prophets how it is to be conducted.

Paragraph 1: the nefesh we share with animals

As learned in Part 1, Chapter 3, what makes a human unique is that he is composed of two utterly different entities, body and soul. At our root we are animals, but we also have something else.

Every human being has a nefesh, as animals do. It gives the basic life force and feeling. An animal is, in the end, a piece of meat; what gives that meat life is the nefesh, and when the animal dies the nefesh departs. Plants have no nefesh, which is why animals have feeling and plants do not.

The Ramhal describes this nefesh as a very subtle entity, drawn into the creature immediately after conception. It spreads through the body and is responsible for its growth and development, growing as the body grows. It is responsible for feeling and also for intelligence. Different animals have different intelligence: a fox is not a pig, and perhaps the dolphin or whale is the cleverest animal. Humans have far more, but it is the same nefesh. "Just like we all have a brain, but some people's brains are better than other people's brains." Each works according to the vessels and the species it is in.

In the human nefesh there are many faculties: imagination, memory, intellect and will. That is why the Torah sometimes uses nefesh for will, as when Avraham says to the people of Het, "im yesh et nafshekhem," if it is your will. Every person has a different mix: some are very imaginative but have poor memories, and so on.

A participant asked whether the blood is the life force, since "the blood is the nefesh." The Rabbi explained that the meat of the brain is just meat; what animates it, the activity running through it, is the nefesh. The Ramhal does not call the nefesh material, but neither is it fully spiritual. It is "the lowest level of something spiritual," something very subtle within the blood, which the blood sustains. When we die it goes, and the brain is just meat.

Paragraph 2: the higher soul, the neshamah

In humanity, the Ramhal says (and the Rabbi noted he speaks of "adam," without distinguishing Jews from non-Jews), there is a second, higher spiritual component, distinct from the animal soul. Its purpose is to connect a person to the spiritual roots of creation and enable him to influence the spiritual worlds.

The Rabbi explained with what was learned at the end of Part 1, Chapter 5: everything physical has a mirror in the spiritual world. Everything else in this world is only reactive: if the spiritual force behind this table breaks down, the table breaks. Human beings are active. We choose, we cause changes in the spiritual realms, and that causes further influence (shefa) to come down, a constant cycle. The nefesh cannot connect to those forces. An animal cannot choose and cannot affect the spiritual worlds; only the neshamah makes it possible. A participant asked whether speech is the key; the Rabbi said speech is a symptom of the neshamah.

Asked whether a human soul can be reincarnated in an animal, he said in short no: some believe it, but it is fringe, and many Rishonim did not believe in gilgul at all.

The hierarchy runs: influence from the upper worlds comes to the neshamah, the higher nefesh which only humans have; the neshamah directs the lower nefesh; and the lower nefesh is bound to the most subtle part of the blood, which gives life to the body. This, the Rabbi said,

is why the Torah speaks of "nefesh ki tehete," a nefesh that sins. The neshamah does not sin; it is the lower nefesh, our animal drive, that sins.

Paragraph 3: a soul bound to the body

Because the neshamah is tied to the body, it is limited. It cannot be a free agent or connect fully to the spiritual worlds; if it could, you would know what was happening there. It is affected by the actions of the body. There is a constant battle, the body pulling down and the neshamah lifting up. If the neshamah becomes subservient to the body and always plays "second fiddle," a person slowly cuts his connection with the higher realms, and can even end up following the forces of evil. The future of the soul depends on what kind of connection it has.

There is one time, apart from death, when the neshamah is free: sleep. The body is no longer in control and its faculties are inactive, which is why the Gemara says sleep is one-sixtieth of death. Then the neshamah can get a taste of what is happening above. This leads to dreams. Are they important? Should we trust them? The Rabbi pointed out that dreams run throughout Bereshit: Avimelekh warned in a dream not to touch Sarah, and soon Yosef's dreams in Vayeshev and Pharaoh's in Mikes. To be continued on Thursday.

Summary

- Part 3 deals with the soul, ruah hakodesh and prophecy, corresponding to the Rambam's sixth and seventh principles.
- Every animal, including man, has a nefesh: a subtle life force in the blood responsible for growth, feeling, intelligence, memory, imagination and will.
- Humans also have a neshamah, which connects them to the spiritual worlds and makes them active rather than merely reactive.
- Influence flows from above to the neshamah, to the nefesh, to the blood and body; it is the nefesh, not the neshamah, that sins.
- The neshamah is constrained by the body, except partly in sleep, which opens the subject of dreams.

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